

Indic Model of Sustainability Sutras

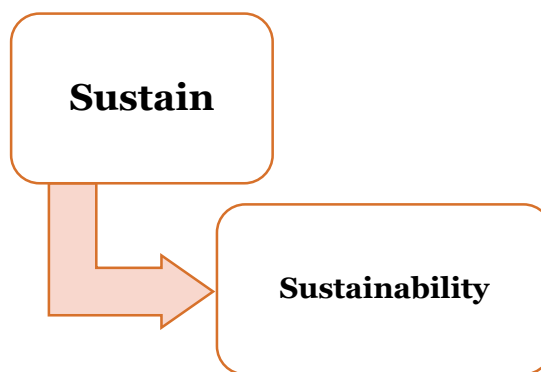
The Indic Manual for Sustainable Future

लोकाः समस्ताः सुखीनः भवन्तु |

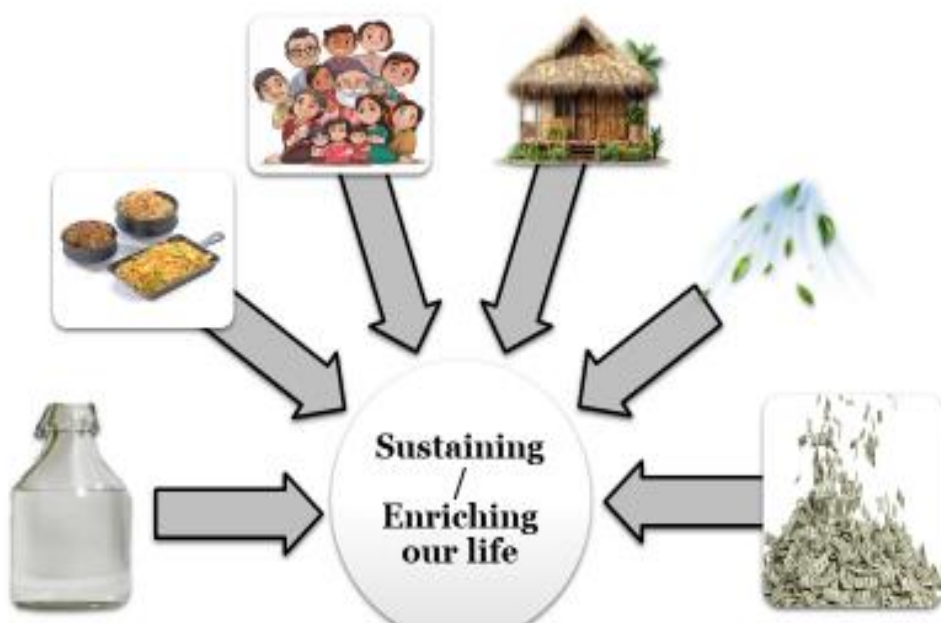
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1. Understanding The Root Word “Sustain”

Before starting the study of sustainability development, we must focus on the word ‘sustainability’ and the root word of sustainability is ‘sustain’. Sustain means to enrich, to keep growing, to support, to nourish. The development that brings out enrichment, nourishment in life of all beings is known as sustainable development.



Food, Water, shelter, Air, Money, People, Family etc. are the things we need in our life for smooth sustenance. These resources sustain the life of all the living beings on the earth. If we observe closely, it is all linked. These resources when conserved and nourished, they will sustain or enrich our life; if the life will be sustained or enriched, the social, economic and environmental harmony of the society will take place and that will lead to sustainable development. Let us see the pictorial presentation of the process that leads to sustainable development.





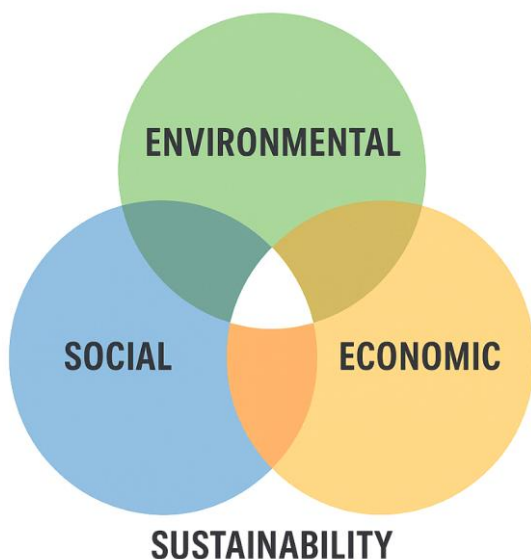
Process That Leads to Sustainable Development

2. Sustainable development

The official definition of sustainable development is, “The practice of meeting the present needs without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs, balancing economic growth, social equity, and environmental protection.”

The crux of this definition is: the resources which help in sustaining our lives should be preserved and we should make judicious use of them in a way that the earth remains sustainable as it is for the future generations. UNESCO has set out a model trying to convey the idea. Let us explore that model.

3. UNESCO’s Model of Sustainability



As per this model a proper sync in the three major dimensions: Environment, Social and Economic will lead to sustainability. All other minor aspects related to sustainable development become the part of this.

Let us see how effective this model has been so far.

4. UNESCO’s sustainable model and its effect

As per the process mentioned above, this UNESCO’s model is it effective? Majorly the world today follows this model. Has this model successful in eradicating the imbalance and scarcity of resources today in the society?

In the previous era when there wasn't any proper model of development, we find that things like infrastructure, amenities, opportunities and global platforms etc... kind of things were not there but sustenance was easy, like people were peaceful and happy, inter and intra personal relationships were sound, balanced and pure food, water, air, socio-economic harmony in society was intact. Observe the below mentioned image.

Back Then ... [Before UN's Model]



Similarly, when we observe this today, even after following the UN's model of sustainable development the balance has been disturbed. The below mentioned image shows how still this distortion is taking place. Today, development has taken place but at infrastructural and external level, the internal and individual level is going down in terms of sustenance; observe the image given below-

Even After Adopting This UN's Model, The Current Scenario Is:



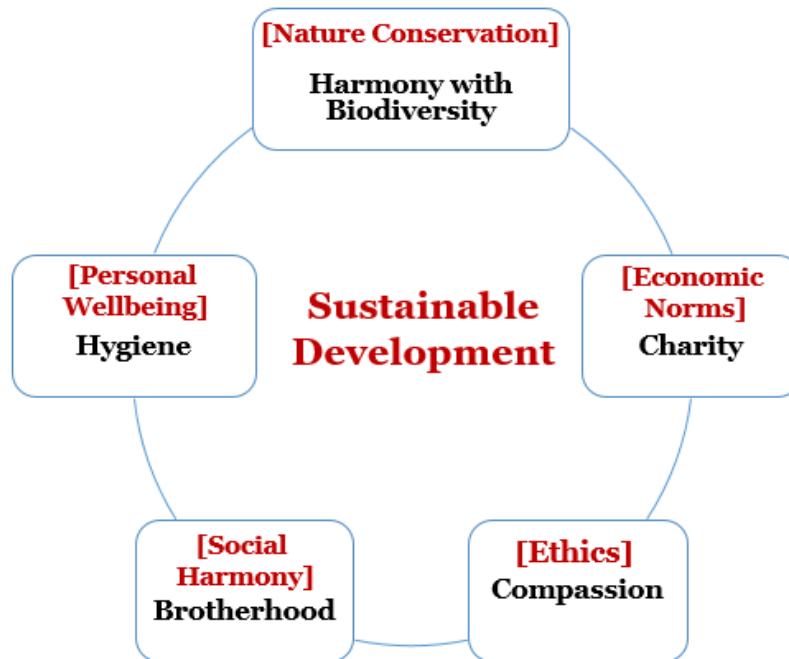
After adopting this sustainable development model, situations at social level and at individual level should have been improved. If we go by its definition, the current generation has to use resource sin a way that the future generations can also sustain, do you think this thing is taking place while we are following this model?

5. Which more categories can be added to the existing model of sustainable development to make it more effective?

If the existing model of sustainable development is less precise and effective, then we must explore another new model or at least make this model more enriched by adding other important categories in it. Categories like: world as a family, Ashram formations, Nature conservation, food as a prana, gratitude for life, Importance of Vata, Animal protection, Acknowledging Rishis and Sages, Agriculture and Land importance, Divinity, water worship, Ideal governance, compassion, hygiene, harmony with biodiversity, Charity, earth. Etc... Adding all these major categories will make Indic model of sustainable development. Let us explore this model.

6. Indic Model of Sustainable Development & Its Major Categories

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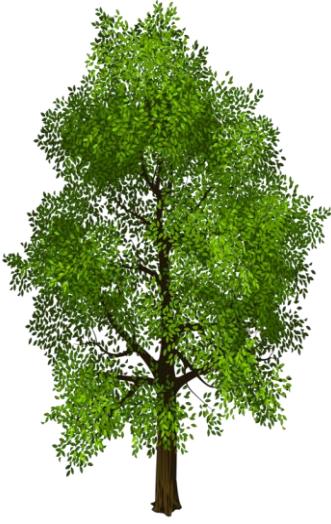


This model is fulfilled with many other categories. Unlike UN's model which broadly puts everything in 3 major categories, this model expressly and out-loud speaks about different norms that should be addressed and dealt with specifically. For example: 'Brotherhood' can be included in the part of 'social' category of UN's model. But still, spreading awareness regarding it specifically by making it a separate category will bring out more awareness.

7. How Is Indic Model of Sustainable Development More Effective?

Many civilizations have been attacked and invaded. The story is no different for Indian Civilization as well. Even after invasions, the Indian civilization stands still even today. One of the chief reasons is the ethos and sustainable models of Indian civilization. The rituals, practices, education, festivals this uniqueness of Indian civilization has made it possible for generations to stand still even today.





An age-old civilization, Indian civilization suffered but still evolved in a better way. Its' existence even today is the evidence of the authenticity of the civilizational ethos and sustainable models. Hence, for the sustainable development as well, the Indic model is reliable.



8. Exploring Five Major Categories of Indic Model Of Sustainable Development

The Indic model of sustainable development has 5 major categories in it;

1. Harmony with Biodiversity [Nature Conservation]
Trees, Animals, Water-Rivers, Earth-Land
2. Charity [Economic Norms]
3. Compassion [Ethics]
4. Brotherhood [Social Harmony]
5. Hygiene [Personal Wellbeing]

A. Harmony with biodiversity [Nature Conservation]

Trees

Animals

Water – Rivers

Earth – Land

Trees

पुष्पं पुष्पं विचिन्वीत मूलच्छेदं न कारयेत्।

मालाकार इवारण्ये न यथाङ्गारकारकः॥

-Viduraniti, Mbh (2.18)

A king should collect taxes from his subjects, like the gardener who very carefully plucks flowers, without hurting the plants, not like the coal-maker who uproots the trees in his quest. Similarly, like a gardener, we should take from nature only what we need, without causing harm.

अश्वत्थमेकं पिचुमंदमेकं न्यग्रोधमेकं दश चिञ्चिणीकान् ।

कपित्थबिल्वामलकीत्रयं च पञ्चाग्रवापी नरकं न पश्येत् ।

-Bh.P 4.128.11

He who plants one Peepal, one Neem and one Banyan tree; ten Tamarind and three each of Kapitha, Bel and Amala trees and five Mango trees goes to heaven. Planting about thirty indigenous trees gives a person enough merit to enter Heaven!



दशकूपसमा वापी, दशवापीसमो हृदः ।

दशहृदसमो पुत्रो, दशपुत्रसमो द्रुमः ॥

-Bh. P.154.512

The merit earned by building a pond is worth the merit of building ten wells; merit earned by building a large water reservoir is same as the merit earned by building ten ponds; merit earned by raising an environmentally conscious child is equal to that of constructing ten reservoirs; and the merit earned by planting and rearing just one tree is as good as the merit of raising ten children.

As it is mentioned in these verses, Indian civilization has been not only respecting but worshipping the trees and biodiversity. Bringing this awareness of considering trees as a living entity and worshipping as a superior being, brings about a change in the way a person behaves with the trees.

Many times we are instructed not to touch or disturb certain trees after evening time so as to keep their slowing down process undisturbed. Almost each and every ritual and festival of India contains the involvement of trees in one or the other way, which indirectly boosts the awareness of protecting and growing more trees. Indic model has made a separate category of biodiversity so as to specifically pay attention to it.

Animals

देवपशुमृषभमुक्षाणं गोकुमारीं वा वाहयतः पञ्चशतो दण्डः प्रवासयत उत्तमः ॥

- KA.4.13.20

Riding or driving a temple animal, a stud bull or a pregnant cow is a punishable act.

हस्तिघातिनं हन्युः ॥

- KA.2.2.8

Whoever kills an elephant shall be put to death.

In Indic model, animals are not only protected but also linked with gods and goddesses to enhance their importance in the view of common people. If we observe the rituals and festivals of India they include feeding and worshipping the animals on every special occasion.

Before any research or models, Indic model was enriched with the idea that sustaining flora and fauna will eventually sustain the mankind.



Water – Rivers

चतुर्विधानां भूतानां तडागः परमाश्रयः ॥

तडागादीनि सर्वाणि दिशन्ति श्रियमुत्तमाम् ॥

देवा मनुष्या गन्धर्वाः पितरो नागराक्षसाः ॥

स्थावराणि च भूतानि संश्रयन्ति जलाशयम् ॥

-SP.5.12.10-11

The lake is the greatest resort of all types of living beings. The construction of wells, tanks, lakes etc. indicates excellent glory. The gods, human beings, Gandharvas, Pitrs, Nagas, Rākṣasas, and even the immobile beings like plants depend upon water bodies.



As mentioned in this verse, Indic model always believed that a land fulfilled with sufficient water bodies, wells, lakes, tanks etc... is the symbol of prosperity. The definition of prosperity was- resources in abundance. People were trained and motivated to conserve and build waterbodies which eventually help them to prosper in their lives and maintaining health and wellbeing.

Major pilgrimage places were constructed by the side of river; civilization has been thriving near the rivers since ages. One of the chief reasons is to convey the idea that water sustains life and civilization. It should not only be conserved but also revered and worshipped.

Earth – Land

विश्वस्वं मातरमोषधीनां ध्रुवां
भूमिं पृथिवीं धर्मणा धृताम् ।
शिवां स्योनामनु चरेम विश्वहा ॥

-AV.12.1.17

Salutations to mother earth! the herbs (plants) which are like mothers of the world (who sustain us) grow on the immovable earth (bhoomi); the earth which is held by dharma, and in which auspiciousness gently pervades throughout the world.

The process of sustainable development which we saw above, is clearly mentioned in this verse. Land, earth, Bhoomi; is the place where herbs, plants, trees and water etc will be held. These herbs, plants, trees and water are the basic resources which sustain our life. For mankind to live healthily and happily it is conserving the biodiversity is mandatory. People were trained in such a way since beginning to conserve the land and other biodiversity will automatically be conserved.

Not only this, but even the way has been shown here as to how to conserve earth i.e. with *Dharma*- पृथिवीं धर्मणा धृताम्.

The entire guide is given here leading to

sustainable development. To sustain, cherish the biodiversity, to cherish the biodiversity conserve the land, to conserve the land, follow the path of Dharma.

Here, we can see, how only in meagre few verses, the proper roadmap is presented to a prosperous and peaceful life balancing the nature and maintaining the harmony. Our scriptures are full of such ready reckoners. This was only one category of “biodiversity” now let us explore another category of Indic wisdom for sustainable ecology.



B. Charity [Economic Norms]

अभयं सर्वभूतेभ्यो व्यसने चाप्यनुग्रहः।
यच्चाभिलषितं दद्यात् तृषितायाभियाचते॥
दत्तं मन्येत यद्वत्ता तद्दानं श्रेष्ठमुच्यते।
दत्तं दातारमन्वेति यद्दानं भरतर्षभ॥

-M.AP.59.2-3

Bhishma said to Yudhiṣṭhira, “O chief of the Bharatas! An assurance unto all creatures of love and affection; abstention from every kind of injury; acts of kindness and favour done to a person in distress; gifts of articles made unto one who deserves; where the giver gives without hint of ego and expects nothing in return are best gifts.”

प्राणान् ददाति भूतानां तेजश्च भरतर्षभ।
गृहमभ्यागतायाथ यो दद्यादन्नमर्थिने॥

-M.AP.63.42



That man who gives food to one who comes into his house and solicits it, is said, O chief of the Bharatas, to contribute both life and energy unto living creatures.

“Charity” as a part of economic norms of the society- is one of the unique characteristics of the Indian Civilization. Since beginning, through different scriptures, poems, epics and other fiction works, the Indian authors and sages have always tried to inculcate the importance of charity.

Currently, the issue of financial inequality in society that is visible was not much of an issue in ancient time, the reason is ‘Charity’ was seen as a virtue and was appreciated and acknowledged. When people used to follow the king, they used to see how kings used to donate their resources and desired things to the needy people.

This was followed even by the people. Charity has been linked to certain festivals, rituals, special religious days or occasions so as to maintain the balance in the society. It not only helps in the sustenance of the poor and needy but also grooms the giver by maintaining their down-to-earth and humble attitude.

Certain religions and religious sects have noted that their devotees should earn more wealth and resources specifically and specially to donate. This unique aspect syncs society and this practice of charity naturally creates balance in society along with developing personal attitude.



C. Compassion [Ethics]

विसृज्य स्मयमानान् स्वान् दृशं ब्रीडां च दैहिकीम् ।

प्रणमेद् दण्डवद् भूमावाश्चचाण्डालगोखरम् ॥

BP.11.29.16

Disregarding the ridicule of one's companions, one should give up the bodily conception and its accompanying embarrassment. One should offer obeisance before all — even the dogs, outcastes, cows, and asses — falling flat upon the ground like a rod.

The root cause of inequality is lack of compassion. The famous misconception about Indian epics and some certain scriptures is about the idea of inequality towards certain castes or certain animals or people. Verses like this are the evidence that show how the Indian civilization gave equal importance to all the animals and outcastes.



This is one of the chief reasons why the ancient society was not divided in caste but *Varna* [which is a systematic division according to the work and duties] inequality or injustice was never a part of active society.

Compassion was always seen as social ethics which was promoted in every possible way amongst the people. The question is, do we see such efforts for society coming up from anywhere today?

D. Brotherhood [Social Harmony]

अयं निजः परो वेति गणना लघुचेतसाम् ।

उदारचरितानां तु वसुधैव कुटुम्बकम् ॥

- महोपनिषद् 6.71

The narrow minded people classify the world into 'mine' and 'not-mine' categories. They love and take care of only that which they consider as 'mine', and greedily exploit everything that they consider 'not mine'. And then there are those big-hearted people, who consider the whole world as their family. They take care of all living and non-living in this world as if they are their own kith and kin.



आपो हि ष्ठा मयोभुवस् ता नऽरुर्जे दधातन । म॒हे रणाय चक्षसे

यो वः शिवतमो रसस्तस्य भाजयतेह नः । उ॒शती॒रिव मातरः

तस्माऽअरं गमाम वो यस्य क्षयाय जिन्वथ । आपो जनयथा च नः

द्यौः शान्तिर् अन्तरिक्षशान्तिः पृथिवी शान्तिर् आपः शान्तिर् ओषधयः शान्तिः ।

वनस्पतयः शान्तिर् विश्वे देवाः शान्तिर् ब्रह्म सर्वं शान्तिः शान्तिर् एव शान्तिः सा मा शान्तिर् एधि ॥

दृते दृह मा मित्रस्य मा चक्षुषा सर्वाणि भूतानि सम् ईक्षन्ताम्।

मित्रस्याहं चक्षुषा सर्वाणि भूतानि समिक्षे। मित्रस् चक्षुषा सम् ईक्ष्यामहे॥

-SYV.36.12-18

May the Waters become auspicious for us to drink. May the flowing waters bless us. May the Earth goddess be pleasant and free of thorns as our place of rest. May she grant us peace. May the Divine Waters grant us blessings! May they sustain our vigour and energy! May we partake of that which is their most auspicious essence, as from loving mothers. May the Heaven grant us peace! May the Airspace grant us peace! May the Earth grant us peace! May the Waters grant us peace! May the medicinal herbs and the great forest trees grant us peace! May the Devas grant us peace! May the Brahman grant us peace!

We can see here the concept of “mine” is taken in a very broad and holistic way. It includes everything related to me including my family, my relatives, my neighbourhood, animals, birds and society, everything belongs to me. Verses like this are answer to people who think Indian society and Indian knowledge lacks wisdom, openness and inclusivity.

In the scriptures, in the epics, always the heroes and representatives of the Indian civilization have been portrayed as an inclusive personality who takes along his entire nation with him wherever he goes. May it be Shri Rama or may it be Yudhishtir. Personalities like Shri Krishna, Swami Vivekananda, Adi Shankaracharya have always been an ideal for the entire world. Who taught the lessons of brotherhood and ideal society by living it personally!

Today when we pray for ourselves or our families and loved ones, our ancestors were habituated to pray for the entire world, वसुधैव कुटुम्बकम् – is the phrase that represents the Indian civilizational ethos. ‘World is an echo’/ ‘What goes around comes around’ such kind of thoughts which are coming from west now, have their roots in Indian Civilization.

Indian Civilization has given this world a broader outlook of sustainable development, it is not merely give and take relation that works but it is a holistic approach of brotherhood that will help the world to sustain; without taking away the ability of the future generation to sustain and that will be true sustainable development.

E. Hygiene [Personal Wellbeing]

छायाकूपनदीगोष्ठचैत्यान्तः पथि भस्मसु

अग्नौ वेश्मश्मशाने च विष्मूत्रे न समाचरेत् ।

न गोपथे न कृष्टे वा महावृक्षे न शाङ्वले । ।

-Ku P. 13.36-37

Areas in and around wells and rivers, shrines and temples, cowsheds, roads, ashes, fire-altars and cremation ground should never be used for excreting. It is prohibited to pollute the roads that are used by the cows, irrigated



lands, the foots of huge trees, grassy meadows and mountain tops by urination or excretion.



पांसुन्यासे रथ्यायामष्टभागो दण्डः

पङ्कोदकसंनिरोधे पादः ॥

राजमार्गे द्विगुणः ॥

-KA.2.36.26-27

Upon throwing dirt on the streets, the person will be fined one eighth of his income, upon letting mud and water collect there, he will be fined one fourth of his income. The fine will be doubled in case this happens on the highways.

Not only morally but also efforts were made for people to abide by the rules consciously. There have been separate texts called *Dharmshashtras* which proclaim the strict actions against the citizens who fail in their duties towards the nation.

From an individual to society, from society to state, from state to Nation and from Nation to the world. Following this roadmap, only, sustainable development can take place. And this roadmap is the Indic model of Sustainable development which works equally at the grass root level by the categories like ‘compassion, charity, hygiene’ and also at the social and global level through categories like ‘harmony with biodiversity, brotherhood’. Until and unless the work is done at the grass-root level, the bigger things cannot be fixed on its own.

The key takeaway from this lecture is the world today needs a more holistic model which can bring the equilibrium in the society first by bringing a sync in the person himself and then aligning him with the society, which naturally results in sustainable development.